

Scottish Economic Insights

Office of the Chief Economic Adviser



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Main data up to 20 March 2026.

Cover page Image of peat sampling at Blawhorn Moss © Dougie Barnett NatureScot

Overview

This edition of the Scottish Economic Insights report focuses on economic conditions across 2025 and initial indicators for 2026 and the year ahead.

Global economic conditions, already challenging over the past year with elevated geopolitical risks and trade uncertainty, have deteriorated further with the recent military conflict in the Middle East creating a logistics supply shock that has disrupted oil and gas supplies from the region with a sharp rise in oil and gas prices and upward pressure on bond yields. This has quickly translated into impacts on prices, increasing some prices for consumers, risking wider inflationary pressures, and weakening prospects for economic growth in the year ahead.

Developments in the Middle East continue to evolve at pace. At this stage, the scale and breadth of these economic impacts will depend to a large extent on the duration of military action, the disruption to oil and gas production and supply from the region and the extent to which impacts spill over into wider commodities and economic channels.

These latest developments have emerged at a time when a number of economic conditions in Scotland have stabilised and improved over the past year. Scotland's economic growth strengthened for a second consecutive year in 2025 to 1.4% with the pace of growth slightly above forecast, albeit below the long run average. Inflation had eased with CPI falling to 3% in January, enabling the Bank of England to cut the bank rate to 3.75%, its lowest rate since the start of 2023. In its most recent meeting however, the Bank's Monetary Policy Committee voted unanimously to hold the rate unchanged, citing the inflationary impacts of the Middle East conflict.

Despite the wider improvements in economic conditions, business and consumer conditions have remained challenging, reflected in ongoing weakness in business and consumer sentiment indicators, though they have improved at the start of the year (prior to the military conflict in the Middle East). The persistence of subdued demand and pressures on profit margins have contributed to a loosening in the labour market from a position of tightness in recent years, although unemployment remains low by historic standards at 3.9%. The number of payrolled employees has fallen over the year, albeit there has been indications of improved stability through the turn of the year, and earnings growth slowed in the final quarter of 2025 and is expected to moderate further this year.

In January, the Scottish Fiscal Commission forecast the economy to grow 1.3% in 2026 and 2027. However, the conflict in the Middle East presents increased uncertainty and risks to current conditions and this outlook, particularly if there is a prolonged disruption to oil and gas and higher prices start to feed into inflation more broadly.

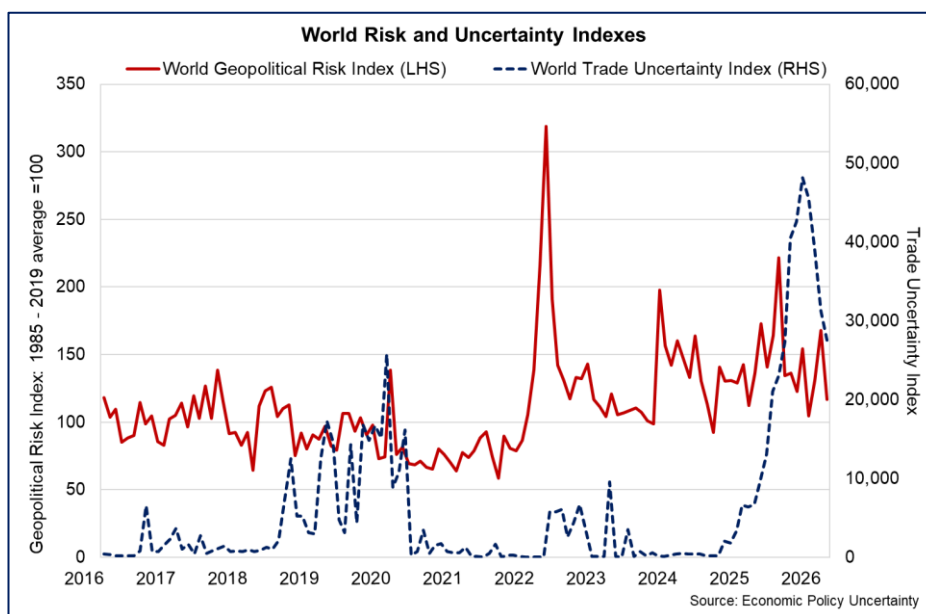
We are already starting to see increases in petrol, diesel and heating oil prices. Household's domestic energy prices more broadly are protected in the short term through the energy price cap, however further changes to fiscal and monetary policy may be required to counter inflationary pressures and support households and businesses.

This edition also presents economic insights on four important topics: The role of natural capital on the economy, measuring business sentiment, estimating alternative labour market indicators and measuring adoption rates of Artificial Intelligence in the Scottish economy.

Recent economic developments

Global context

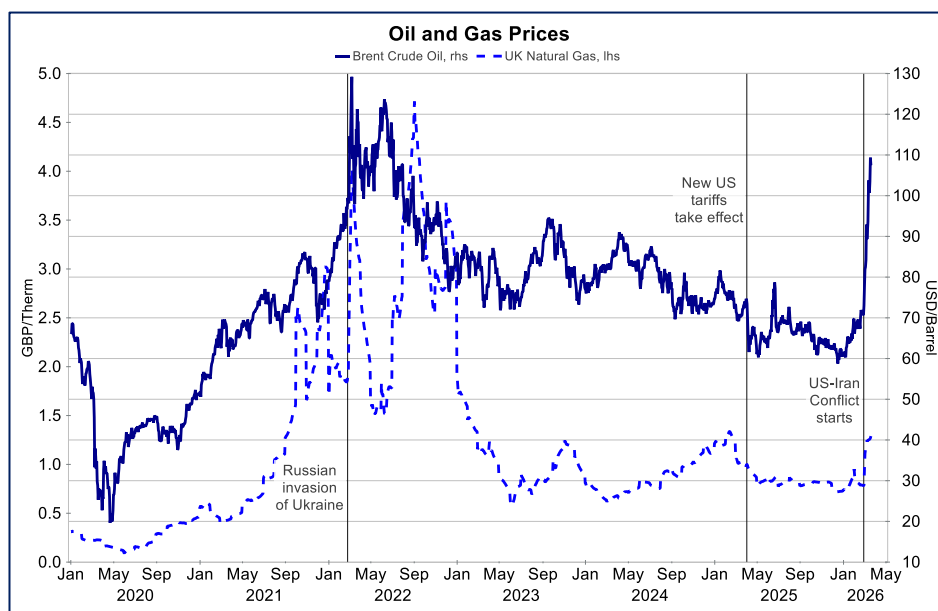
Global economic uncertainty and risks to the economic outlook have risen significantly following the military conflict in the Middle East. Since the US and Israel air strikes at the end of February and subsequent retaliation by Iran, the widening of military impacts on countries across the region and the significant disruption to oil and gas supplies from the region has resulted in a notable rise in the potential global economic implications in both the near and medium term. This comes on the back of a range of global geopolitical and trade tensions over the past year which have presented a challenging global environment for businesses and households to navigate.



The Middle East accounts for around 3% of global GDP, however its importance in the global production of oil and gas, other commodities such as fertiliser components, and as hubs of international travel, mean that the disruption to the regional economy presents significant supply and inflationary risks across a range of energy and commodity markets and into sectors including international travel and tourism.

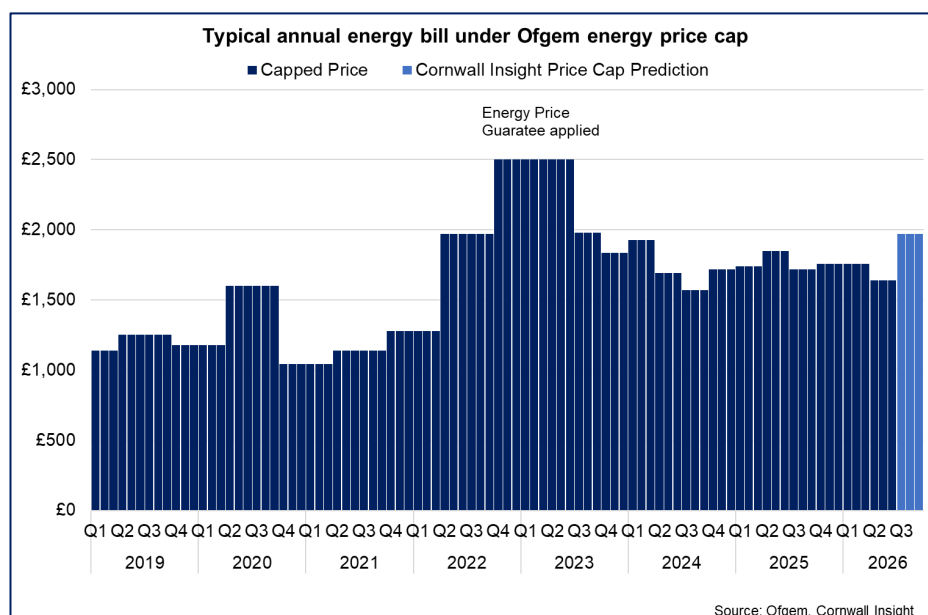
The most prominent impact at this point in the conflict is the significant disruption to oil and gas production and supply from the region and the implications this could have for global inflationary pressures the longer the disruption continues. The Middle East accounts for c. 30% of global oil production and c. 20% of global natural gas production, however the shipping of exports through the Strait of Hormuz has been brought to a virtual standstill due to the risks of attack, while military action has directly impacted on refinery and gas facilities in countries including Saudi Arabia and Qatar.

In response to this, Brent Crude oil has risen above \$100 per barrel, spiking at one point at £119, while UK natural gas prices have broadly doubled and have spiked to 164 p/therm.



The extent to which this feeds through into domestic inflationary pressures in higher energy prices remains uncertain and will depend on how long the supply disruption and price pressure lasts. The most immediate impacts have been increases in heating oil prices and road fuel prices which will directly impact household costs, particularly in rural areas.

In terms of household electricity and gas prices, the Energy Price Cap is currently set for the first half of 2026, which will see a 7% fall in April for the average household (set prior to the start of the conflict). This means that the impact on energy bills will not be felt before July. Early forecasts, based on information through the first half of March, indicate a 20% increase in the cap at that point, however there remains significant uncertainty and will depend on how energy prices evolve over the coming months.¹



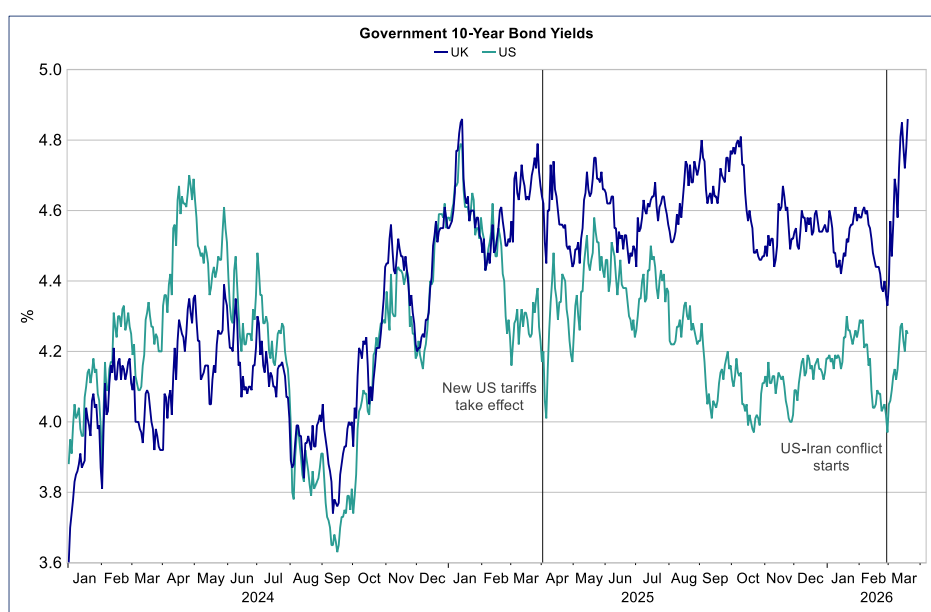
¹ Predictions & Insights into the Default Tariff Cap (Price Cap)

In terms of the extent to which the increase in oil prices feed through to CPI inflation more broadly will depend on how long oil prices remain elevated, with external commentators providing a range of estimates. An early scenario projection from the Resolution Foundation suggests that a 20% increase and doubling of wholesale prices for oil and gas respectively, sustained for a quarter, would add around £500 to the typical annual energy bill for households on a price cap tariff, and raise the rate of inflation by around 1 percentage point.²

NIESR consider two scenarios based on oil prices rising to \$100 per barrel and gas prices more than doubling. In a scenario which assumes that energy prices begin to normalise after one quarter this would result in a 0.3 p.p increase in inflation and a negligible impact on GDP for 2026. If the increase persisted for a year, this would increase inflation by 0.7 p.p and would reduce output growth by 0.2% in 2026.³

Both these estimates suggest that the impact on domestic inflation will be lower than that seen in the first year of the Russian invasion of Ukraine in 2022 which is shown in the inflation chart in the household conditions section.

The channels through which a more prolonged military conflict and disruption to oil and gas supply would impact the global economy are broader than through energy inflationary channels. An increase in expectations that Central Banks will need to maintain interest rates higher than they otherwise would have has put upward pressure on bond yields (cost of government borrowing) and wider expectations of borrowing costs, with reports of increases in mortgage rates. Furthermore, a spillover from higher oil and gas supply disruption and pricing into other commodity and global supply chain costs, for example fertiliser and food prices, risks further exacerbating wider inflationary pressures, weighing on global and domestic trade and investment flows and growth.



² [Understatement of the year • Resolution Foundation](#)

³ [Middle East Conflict: Macroeconomic Impacts of Rising Oil and Gas Prices - NIESR](#)

The table below presents the current risk profile to the Scottish economy across a range of economic outturn indicators in 2025 and the start of 2026 (prior to the escalation of the conflict in the Middle East), based on their position related to historical trends.

As set out above, the conflict currently presents a new inflationary risk to the Scottish economy through the increase in oil and gas prices, however the overall risk to headline inflation and wider indicators remains uncertain at this point and will depend on how prolonged the disruption to global oil supplies is.

The conflict has the potential to exacerbate the existing most notable downside (red) risks to the Scottish economy that have persisted over the past year, in part through global geopolitical and trade uncertainty channels, demand in the economy and through public finances and costs to businesses. It also risks compounding risks which have worsened over the past year in consumer sentiment and policy uncertainty.

There are a number of risks that remain fragile (amber) in the Scottish economy at this point, mainly around the relatively subdued, albeit positive, growth in GDP and business activity. Unemployment remains low in the Scottish economy, however there has been a loosening in labour market conditions around employment. Above target headline inflation remains fragile, with risks building from the conflict and potentially impacting international food prices.

Alongside low unemployment, risks in earnings growth remain stable (green), in part supported by the fall in inflation over the past year which has enabled the stabilisation in risks around interest rates and currency as the previous restrictiveness in monetary policy has been gradually loosened.

Overall, the risk profile in the economy is currently skewed to amber and red, despite there being modest improvements in a number of economic conditions. The conflict in the Middle East has increased uncertainty in the economic outlook and has increased the likelihood that the overall risk profile will worsen rather than improve over the coming year. ⁴

⁴ Sources include: Economic Performance: GDP statistics, S&P Global RBS PMI. Labour Market: Labour Market Statistics, ONS Textkernel and Real Time Information Statistics, and Business Insights and Conditions Survey (BICS). Trade: HMRC Regional Trade Statistics, S&P Global UK PMI, BICS, Economic Policy Uncertainty (EPU). Prices: ONS, Bank of England, Food and Agricultural Organisation of the UN. UK Public Finances: ONS. Outlook: S&P Global RBS PMI, Scottish Consumer Sentiment Indicator, Economic Policy Uncertainty.

Snapshot of Indicators

Colour coding reflects assessment of economic risk for an indicator during 2025 and 2026, relative to historic trends.

Red - expected to remain weak with significant downside risks // **Amber** - expected to remain fragile with downside risks // **Green** - expected to remain broadly stable/fine relative to historic trends.

Economic Performance

Indicator	Latest Data		Monthly Change	Risk (Mar 26)	Risk (Mar 25)
GDP Growth (Three-Monthly)	0.1%	Dec-25	▼	A	A
Business Activity Index (>50 = growth)	50	Jan-26	▲	A	A
New Business (>50 = growth)	47.6	Jan-26	▲	R	R

Labour Market

Indicator	Latest Data		Monthly/Quarterly Change	Risk (Mar 26)	Risk (Mar 25)
<u>Unemployment and Inactivity</u>					
- Unemployment Rate*	3.9%	Nov 25 - Jan 26	▲	G	G
- Claimant Count Rate	3.5%	Feb-26	▲	A	A
Inactivity Rate*	22.1%	Nov 25 - Jan 26	—	A	A
<u>Employment</u>					
- Employment Rate*	74.8%	Nov 25 - Jan 26	▼	A	G
- Payrolled Employees	2.45 million	Feb-26	▼	A	A
Textkernel new online vacancies (annual % change)	7.3%	Jan-26	▲	A	A
Share of businesses expecting employee numbers to fall	9.0%	Feb-26	▼	A	A
<u>Earnings</u>					
Nominal median earnings annual growth	3.6%	Feb-26	▼	G	G
Real median earnings annual growth	1.7%	Jan-26	▲	G	G

UK Public Finances

Indicator	Latest Data		Annual Change	Risk (Mar 26)	Risk (Mar 25)
Bond Yields (UK 10 -year)	4.85%	20-Mar-26	▲	R	R
Public Sector Net Borrowing (PSNB ex) (Financial year to date)	112.1bn	Jan-26	▼	R	R
Public Sector Net Debt (ex PS banks) (% of GDP)	92.2%	Jan-26	—	R	R

* Data is based on ONS Labour Force Survey. Due to current volatility in the data for Scotland the risk ratings for unemployment and employment are based on a wider suite of labour market indicators.

Prices

Indicator	Latest Data		Monthly Change	Risk (Mar 26)	Risk (Mar 25)
Consumer Prices Inflation Rate (CPI)	3.0%	Jan-26	▼	A	A
Business Input Prices (>50 = growth)	63.3	Jan-26	▼	R	R
International Food Prices Index (2014-2016 = 100)	125.3	Feb-26	▼	A	A
Oil Brent Crude (\$/b)	110.0	20-Mar-26	▲	R	G
Bank Rate (%)	3.75%	Mar-26	—	A	A
Exchange Rate (£/\$)	1.34	20-Mar-26	▼	G	A
Exchange Rate (£/€)	1.16	20-Mar-26	▲	G	A

Trade

Indicator	Latest Data		Monthly/Quarterly Change	Risk (Mar 26)	Risk (Mar 25)
Goods Exports (ex oil and gas) (Real growth v same period in 2024)	-4.0%	Year-to-December 2025	n/a	A	A
Share of businesses exporting less than a year ago (or unable to export)	18.9%	Dec-25	▼	A	A
Share of businesses importing less than a year ago (or unable to import)	13.8%	Dec-25	▲	A	A
UK Manufacturing Suppliers' Delivery Time (>50 = improving)	44.6	Feb-26	▼	A	A
World Geopolitical Risk Index (1985-2019 average = 100)	116.7	Feb-26	▼	R	R
World Trade Uncertainty Index	234.1	Q4 2025	▼	R	R

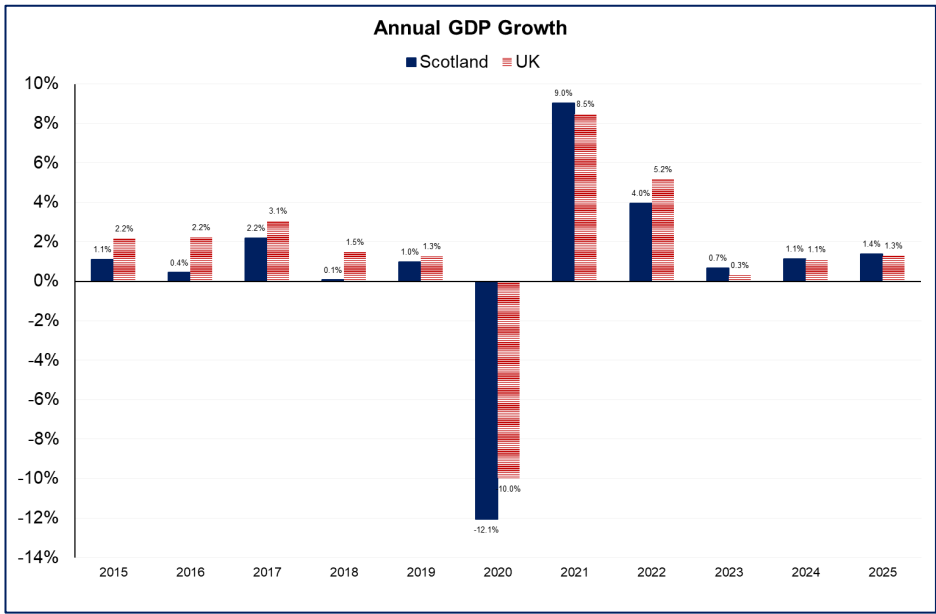
Outlook

Indicator	Latest Data		Monthly Change	Risk (Mar 26)	Risk (Mar 25)
Business Future Expectation (>50 = growth)	59.8	Jan-26	▲	A	A
Consumer Sentiment Index (>0 = positive)	-5.9	Jan-26	▲	R	A
Consumer Sentiment Personal Index (>0 = positive)	-9.2	Jan-26	▲	R	R
Consumer Sentiment Economy Index (>0 = positive)	-0.9	Jan-26	▲	R	A
Economic Policy Uncertainty Index (UK) (pre-2011 average = 100)	182	Feb-26	▼	R	A

Economic growth and business conditions

Economic growth

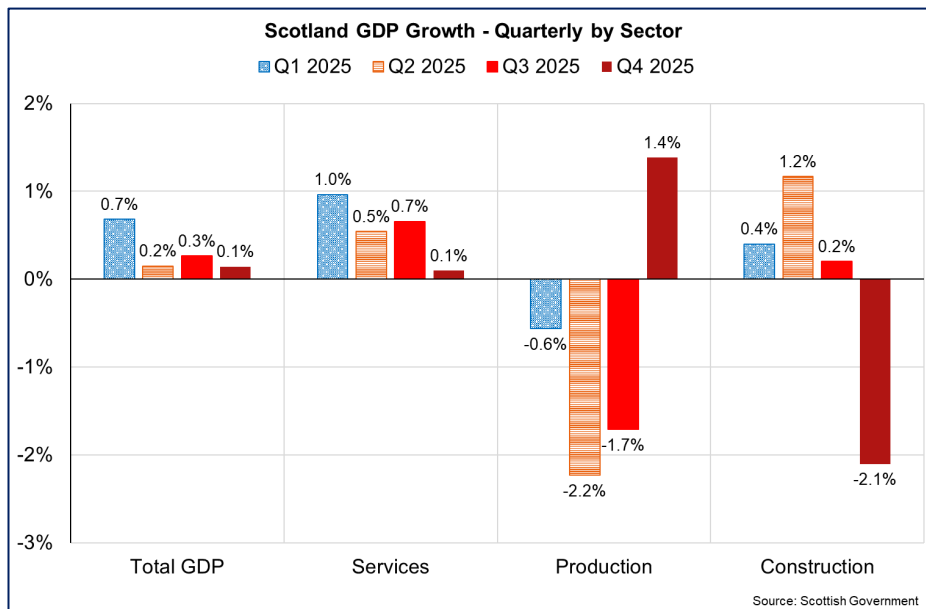
Scotland's economy grew 1.4% in 2025, strengthening from 1.1% in 2024 and 0.7% in 2023. Over the calendar year as a whole, growth was predominantly driven by the services sector (2.0%) and to a lesser extent the construction sector (1.3%). In contrast production sector output fell 1.7%, largely due to a fall in manufacturing output (-4.0%) during a year in which a combination of global headwinds from the changes in US tariffs on goods, and domestic factors including the cessation of oil refining activities at Grangemouth impacted on activity in the sector. There has been a similar pattern of growth at a UK level in 2025 with growth strengthening to 1.3%, up from 1.1% in 2024.⁵



During 2025, the pace of growth was front loaded to the start of the year with growth remaining relatively stable through the second half of the year but slowing to 0.1% in the fourth quarter.

At a sector level, services was the constant driver of growth across the year, however its pace of growth slowed in the fourth quarter to 0.1%. Slower growth was relatively broad based across the services industries with consumer facing services contracting 0.1%.

⁵ [Economy statistics - gov.scot](#), [GDP first quarterly estimate, UK - Office for National Statistics](#)



In contrast, the pace of growth in the production sector in the fourth quarter picked up to its fastest rate since the second quarter of 2024, in part driven by the return to positive growth in manufacturing output (1.5%). During the year, manufacturing of refined petroleum, chemical and pharmaceutical products had been impacted by the cessation of oil refinery activity at Grangemouth in April. However industry output returned to growth in the fourth quarter (6.1%) alongside a pick-up in growth in the manufacture of metals and metal products (6.8%) and computer, electrical and optical products (3.7%).

Taking a broader view of the economy, Scotland's natural capital accounts for a large share of economic output and some sectors of the economy – electricity and agriculture - rely on natural capital (see Box 1).

Box 1: Insights on Scottish economy's reliance on natural capital

Around £40 billion of economic output and around 260,000 full-time equivalent (FTE) jobs can be estimated as the value of natural capital to the Scottish economy, as identified in The Importance of Natural Capital to the Scottish Economy 2024 analysis.⁶ This economic research found only 27% of wider ecosystem services not traded in the market could in theory be substituted by human interventions - meaning the majority of business critical nature is irreplaceable. Two supplementary reports were published in 2026 highlighting insights from the original model - providing regional and marine and terrestrial breakdowns of the economic value of natural capital.^{7,8}

Nature acts as a fundamental, often unpriced, asset base for global and national economies. Natural capital - comprising of ecosystems, biodiversity, soil, water, and minerals - is used to

⁶ [Natural capital - importance to the Scottish economy: research - gov.scot](https://gov.scot/natural-capital-research)

⁷ [Importance of Natural Capital to the Scottish Economy – Regional Analysis - gov.scot](https://gov.scot/natural-capital-research-regional-analysis)

⁸ [Importance of Natural Capital to the Scottish Economy – Marine and Terrestrial - gov.scot](https://gov.scot/natural-capital-research-marine-terrestrial)

recognise how nature underpins societal and economic activity. In 2022, the National Strategy for Economic Transformation (NSET) highlighted how natural capital is crucial in delivering a Wellbeing Economy for Scotland.

Table B1.1: The top 10 industries most dependent on natural capital in Scotland by output and employment, ordered by output.^{9,10}

Industry	Total Output (Direct and Indirect) (£bn)	Total Employment (Direct and Indirect) (FTE)	Share (%) of additional economic natural capital value that cannot be replaced by human intervention
Electricity	£10.5	28,600	84%
Agriculture	£7.6	64,300	59%
Water & sewerage	£2.3	9,500	86%
Aquaculture	£2.3	12,100	59%
Fish & fruit processing	£1.5	8,200	89%
Meat processing	£1.4	8,700	89%
Gas & Air Conditioning	£1.2	2,700	100%
Retail – excl. vehicles	£1.1	15,800	87%
Public administration & defence	£0.9	7,100	87%
Health	£0.7	8,200	100%
Food & beverage services	£0.6	9,400	50%
Education	£0.4	7,800	100%

The research identifies sectors of the Scottish economy reliant on high-quality, renewable natural capital and quantifies their value to the economy. It offers an innovative methodology on how natural capital reliance could be measured within, and beyond, the boundaries of traditional market-based economic statistics by expanding them with the value of ecosystem services not priced in the market, such as pollination, temperature regulation, or water filtration. Whilst these are the best estimates, they only showcase the minimum value of natural capital to the economy.

Scottish National Accounts (SNA) data for 2019 is used as the basis for the analysis, with business activity reliance on nature expanded beyond what is traded in the market. Standard Industrial Classification (SIC) codes are used to look at economic activity at the national and regional levels. Whilst tourism relies heavily on natural capital, it is not a distinct industry in SIC or SNA classifications, therefore it has no standalone estimate. Nonetheless, the impacts on tourism are reflected through the value of other sectors.

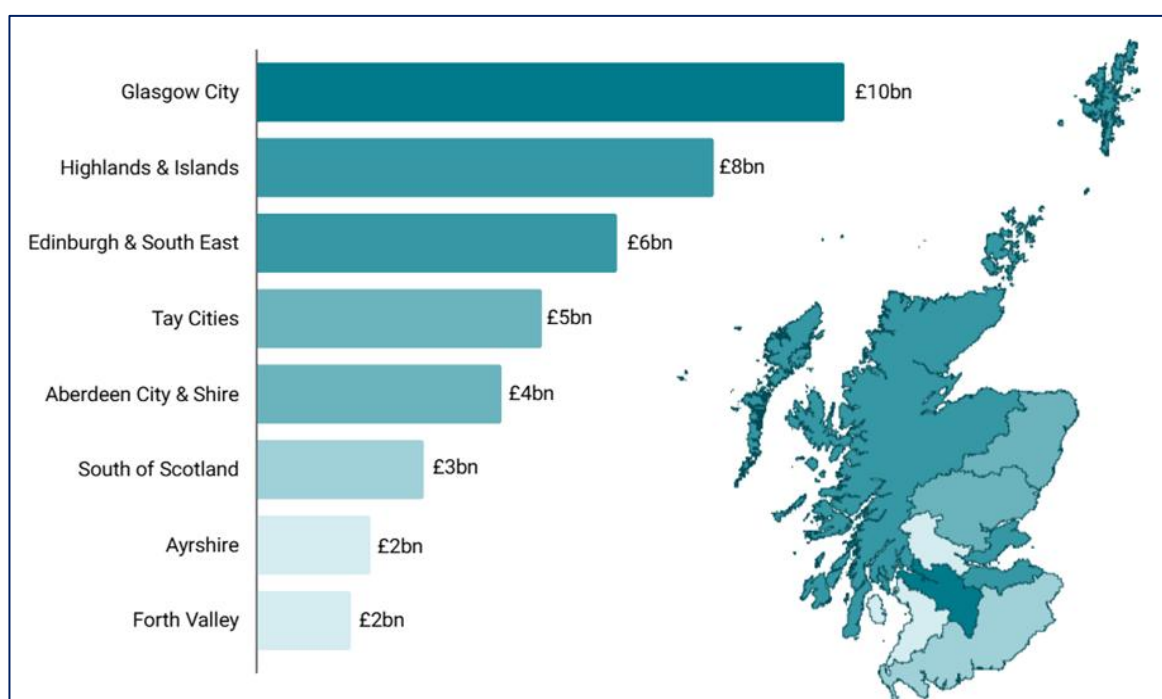
⁹ The top industries reliant on natural capital are ordered by magnitude of output instead of employment. Industries might have high output but low employment, or vice versa. e.g. food and beverage services and education are in the top 10 for employment reliance, but not output reliance.

¹⁰ The share of economic natural capital value that cannot be replaced by human intervention relates to the additional business reliance on wider ecosystem services not traded on the market, like regulating and cultural services e.g. for healthcare services nature benefits are hard to substitute for.

Regional Natural Capital Economic Reliance

The analysis also shows results by Regional Economic Partnerships (REP), with infographics outlining output, employment, and industry reliance on ecosystem services.¹¹ The natural capital value is attributed to where economic activity is estimated to occur, based on employment, not where the physical assets and ecosystem services are located. As a result, Glasgow City REP has the greatest share as, for example, many energy companies have offices, and consequently a large share of jobs, in Glasgow despite the electricity being generated elsewhere in the country.

Figure B1.1: Scotland's Economic Output (£bn) reliant on natural capital by Regional Economic Partnerships.



For example, the Highlands & Islands REP has the second highest amount of output and employment supported by natural capital, due to its extensive agricultural land and coastline. Around £8 billion of the REP's output and around 53,900 FTE jobs can be estimated as the economic value from natural capital. The top 5 industries accounting for the largest share of natural capital reliant economic activity are: agriculture, aquaculture, electricity, fish and fruit processing, water and sewerage.

Marine-Terrestrial Natural Capital Economic Reliance

A supplementary report proposed a new methodology using the original model to attribute natural capital economic reliance to either marine or terrestrial habitats, suggesting that 16% of the identified economic value can be attributed to marine and 84% to terrestrial natural capital.¹²

¹¹ [Supporting documents - Importance of Natural Capital to the Scottish Economy – Regional Analysis - gov.scot](#)

¹² [Importance of Natural Capital to the Scottish Economy – Marine and Terrestrial - gov.scot](#)

Around £6.5 billion of Scotland's total economic output and 38,700 jobs are estimated as the value of marine natural capital to the Scottish economy. On the other hand, around £33.6 billion of Scotland's total economic output and 222,900 jobs are estimated as the value of terrestrial natural capital in Scotland.

Table B1.2: Top 5 industries (according to SIC code classification) most dependent on marine and terrestrial natural capital

Marine Natural Capital	Terrestrial Natural Capital
Aquaculture	Electricity
Fish and Fruit Processing	Agriculture
Electricity	Water and Sewerage
Fishing	Meat Processing
Food and Beverage Services	Gas and Air Conditioning

Innovative Methodology – beyond traditional economic statistics

Defining natural capital dependent industries

First, core natural capital industries which fundamentally rely on ecosystem assets (e.g. agriculture, fishing, forestry) are determined, establishing a proxy for economic reliance. This approach offers alignment with National Accounts approaches, and captures provisioning ecosystem services value. The focus is on industries which rely on nature's ability to regenerate and provide sustainable benefits, meaning non-renewables like oil and gas are excluded from the main analysis.

Quantifying natural capital dependence in the wider economy

Next, businesses which rely on the core natural capital industries are identified using expenditure patterns in order to quantify the wider supply chain economic activity supported by natural capital. This approach offers alignment with National Accounts approaches, and captures provisioning ecosystem services value

Wider ecosystem service dependence not captured in market data

Ecosystem service dependence of industries is scored using the United Nation's ENCORE (Exploring Natural Capital Opportunities, Risks, and Exposure) database to determine the degree to which industrial processes depend on provisioning, regulating and cultural ecosystem services.¹³

To quantify this additional reliance which is most likely not captured in market prices, the share of ecosystem services which could in theory be substituted by human intervention is identified. The

¹³ [ENCORE](#)

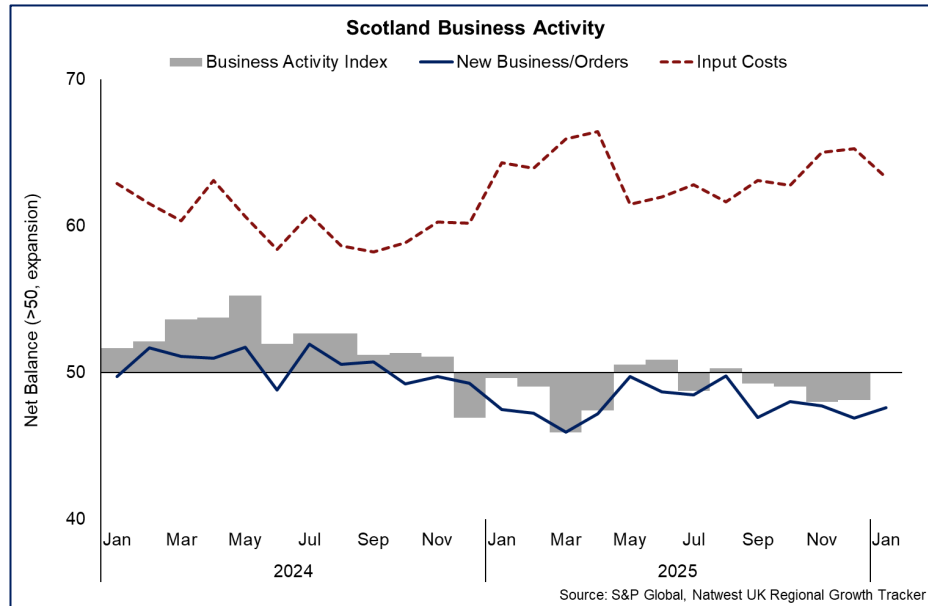
study finds that most ecosystem services cannot be substituted by humans. The economic activity potentially involved in providing the key natural processes is then quantified and added on to the market-based estimates, to arrive at final wider natural capital value estimates.

End of Box 1

Business conditions

Business conditions have remained challenging across 2025 and into the start of 2026 with businesses continuing to report subdued demand, cost pressures and broader economic uncertainty. Latest business survey data reflects on responses before the escalation of the conflict in the Middle East.

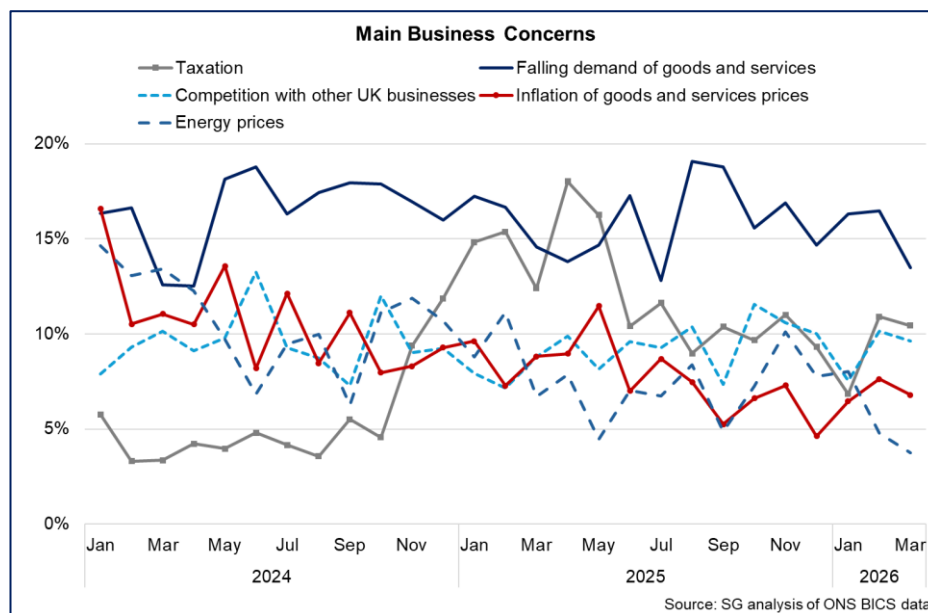
The RBS Growth Tracker business survey indicated a pattern of falling business activity over 2025 in part driven by moderate and persistent contractions in new business orders. Latest data for January this year, indicate that overall business activity was stable during the month with a reading of 50 (a reading below 50 indicates contracting business activity), following four consecutive months of falling activity. However underlying demand remained weak with a further fall in new orders for the sixteenth consecutive month albeit to a lesser extent than in December. Cost of living and economic uncertainty were cited by businesses as weighing on new orders.¹⁴



This pattern has been reflected in business concerns over this period with falling demand for goods and services a main concern through 2025 and into the start of this year. Latest data from the Business Insights and Conditions Survey (BICS) shows 13.5% of businesses reported it as their main concern in March. Taxation as a main business concern remained broadly stable through the

¹⁴ [Regional Growth Tracker report for January 2026 | Royal Bank of Scotland](#)

second half of 2025 following an increase around the UK budget which included an increase in employer NICs. It has remained broadly stable at the start of 2026 with 10.4% of businesses citing taxation as a main concern in March.¹⁵



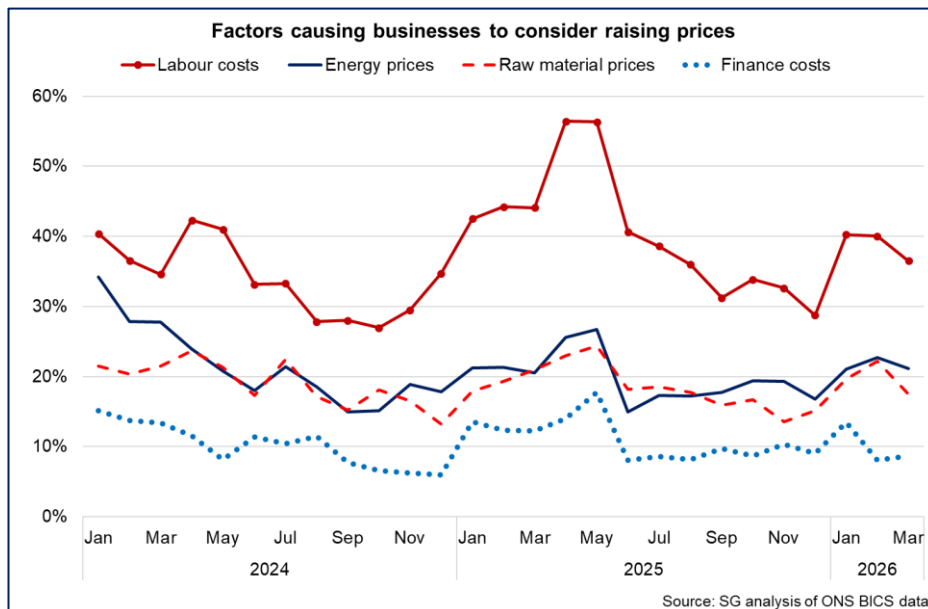
Businesses continued to report cost pressure challenges throughout 2025, and expect them to continue in 2026. The RBS Growth Tracker business survey indicated that growth in input costs strengthened through the second half of 2025, before easing slightly in January. The Scottish Business Monitor for Q4 2025 reported that 89.7% of businesses expected to face higher total costs in the first half of 2026.¹⁶ Most recently, BICS data shows that the proportion of businesses expecting prices to increase, has been elevated at the start of 2026 compared with the latter half of 2025 with 18.3% of businesses expecting the price of goods and services to increase in March (up from an average of 13.3% in the second half of 2025).

Labour costs remain a key source of cost pressures faced by businesses. The Scottish Chambers of Commerce Quarterly Economic Indicator for Q4 2025 showed that a significant proportion of businesses (77%) reported increased cost pressures due to labour costs.¹⁷ Most recently, BICS data showed that 36.5% of businesses reported labour costs as a factor in considering increasing prices in March, followed by energy prices (21.2%) and raw materials (17.5%).

¹⁵ [Business and innovation: statistics - gov.scot](https://businessandinnovation.scot.nhs.uk/statistics)

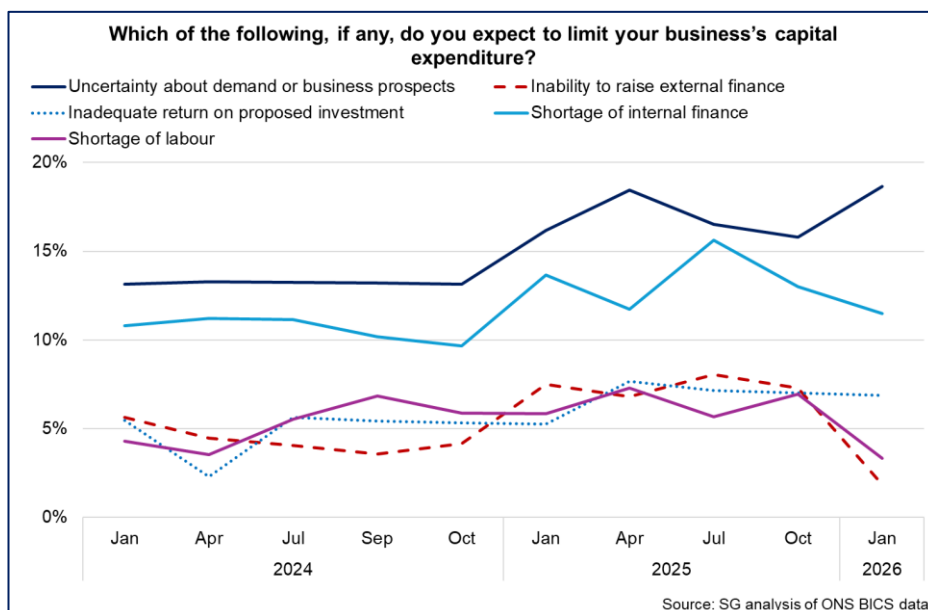
¹⁶ [Scottish Business Monitor Q4 2025 | FAI](https://businessandinnovation.scot.nhs.uk/statistics)

¹⁷ [Quarterly Economic Indicator - Scottish Chambers](https://businessandinnovation.scot.nhs.uk/statistics)



In terms of how the combination of continued cost pressures and subdued demand may impact on business capital expenditure expectations, the Scottish Business Monitor for Q4 2025 showed that the balance of firms reporting an increase in new capital investment fell to its lowest level of the year (-25.0). More recently, latest BICS data from January showed that 15.2% of businesses expected capital expenditure to increase in the first quarter of 2026, up from Q4 2025 but remains below the average shares reported across 2024 and 2025.

Uncertainty about demand or business prospects continues to be the most commonly cited factor expected to limit a business's capital expenditure in Q1 2026 (18.7%), and has increased over the past year, followed by shortage of internal finance (11.5%). There has been a fall in the share of businesses reporting an inability to raise external finance and shortage of labour as limiting factors on capital expenditure, which may reflect the easing of interest rates over the past year and the loosening in the labour market.



Despite ongoing challenging business conditions, the RBS Growth Tracker business survey indicates that business optimism for growth has strengthened through the turn of the year. As set out above, the escalation of the conflict in the Middle East has increased uncertainty in the economic outlook, particularly for inflationary pressures. While there is still significant uncertainty at this stage about the extent to which the conflict will directly impact the economy and business conditions, the increased uncertainty risks weighing on business confidence and potentially investment planning in the coming months.

Business sentiment is a key driver of business decision making and investment and Box 2 sets out the latest evidence on an index of business sentiment index.

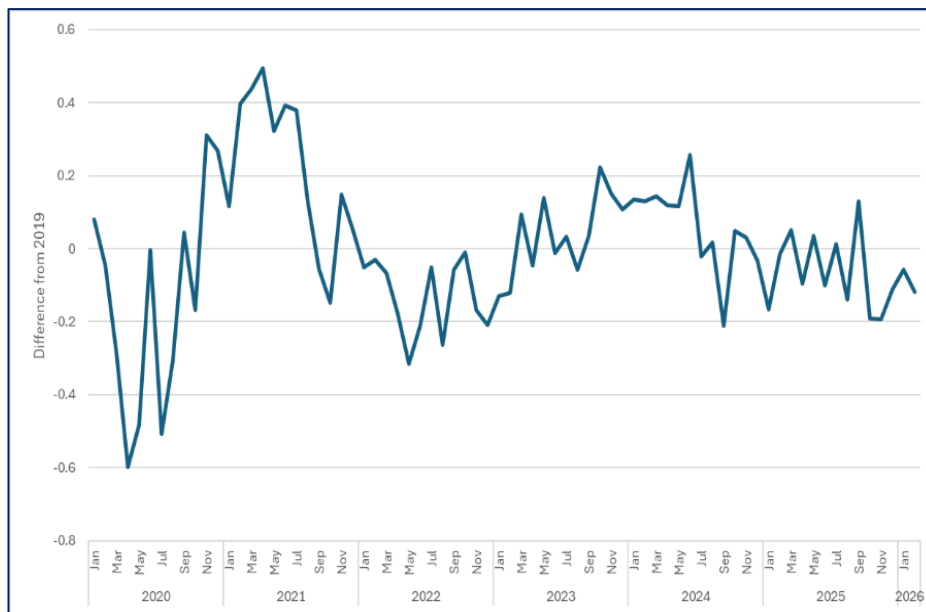
Box 2: Scottish Business Sentiment Index Update

In May 2025, the Scottish Government published the first estimates from a new Scottish Business Sentiment Index (BSI), which aims to provide a comprehensive, real-time measure of business confidence in Scotland by analysing sentiment in news articles related to corporate and industrial developments.¹⁸ This box provides a short update on the index.

The chart below shows the latest monthly data for the BSI, focussing on the period 2020 onwards. The BSI can display relatively large month on month movements, but key trends can be drawn out. Firstly, the effect of the Covid-19 pandemic is clearly visible, as is the recovery, when sentiment improved to relatively high levels. Sentiment then fell back during 2022, which is likely to reflect both a reversion to mean effect and the negative effects on business sentiment of the increase in energy prices following the war in Ukraine and supply chain challenges that were seen after Covid-19 restrictions were fully lifted. However, business sentiment generally improved across 2023 and 2024.

¹⁸ [Scottish Business Sentiment Index - gov.scot](https://www.gov.scot/business-sentiment-index)

Chart B2.1: Scottish Business Sentiment Index.



Business sentiment then fell in the latter half of 2024, which coincided with the increase in business taxes in the UK Budget. Sentiment has remained at this relatively subdued level since, with no signs of sustained recovery or falling further in response to increased global trade and geopolitical uncertainty.

The BSI remains in development, and we welcome further comments from users on how best to present the results.

End of Box 2

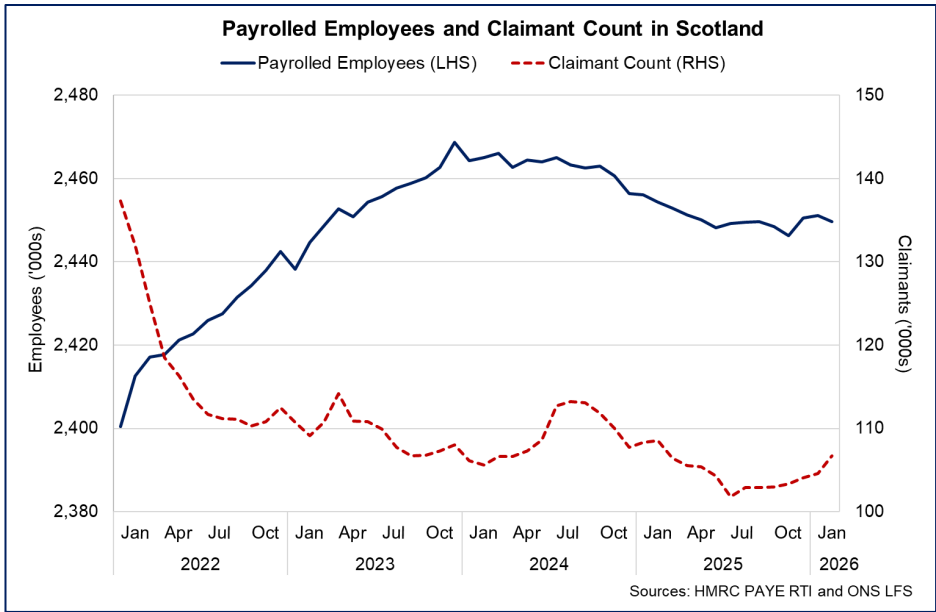
Labour market conditions

Employment and unemployment

Scotland's labour market has continued to be characterised by low unemployment over the past year, however falls in indicators of employee numbers and staffing levels, coupled with slower earnings growth at the end of the year, suggest labour market conditions have loosened over the period. Latest data into the start of 2026, indicate that employment levels have started to stabilise.

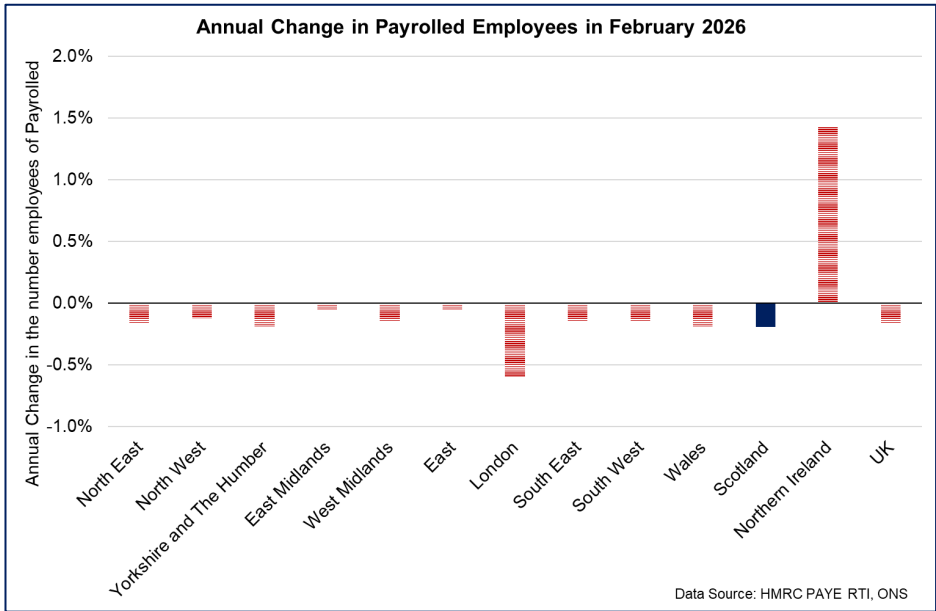
The headline unemployment rate for Scotland has remained low throughout 2025 and in the three months to January 2026 was 3.9%, up by 0.1 p.p. from the three months to October. The continuation of low unemployment has also been reflected in the claimant count unemployment rate which was at 3.5% in February 2026. The number of claimants of unemployment related benefits

has fallen by c. 1,800 (-1.7%) over the past year, however has risen by c. 4,900 since July last year.¹⁹



The rise in the number of claimants of unemployment related benefits in the second half of the year, is likely reflecting the fall in payrolled employees, which have fallen by c. 4,800 (-0.2%) over the past year to 2.45 million in January 2026.

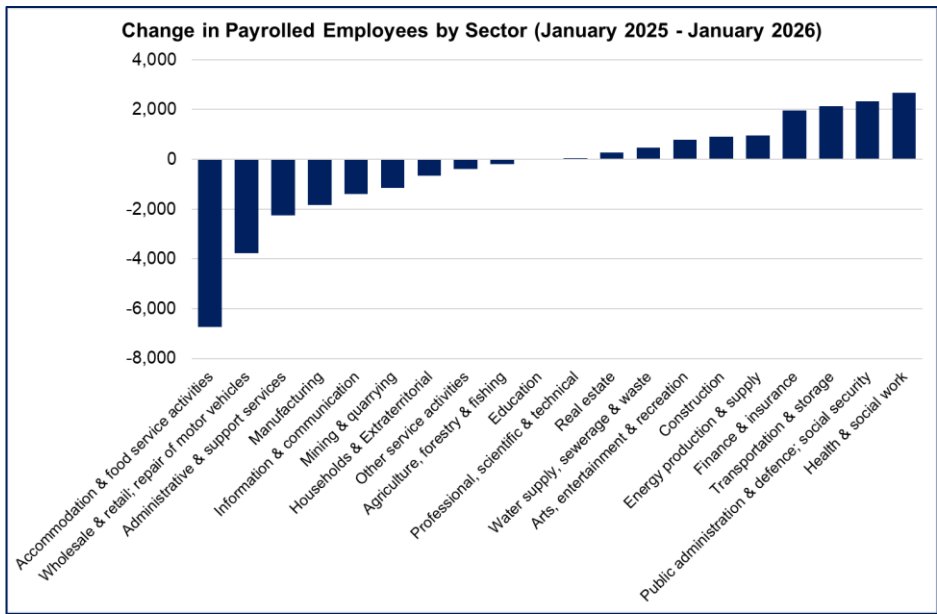
This is a similar trend to nearly all other parts of the UK, with the number of payrolled employees around 49,000 lower than a year ago in the UK as a whole.



In Scotland, the largest fall in the number of payrolled employees over the year, was in the Accommodation and Food Service Activities sector (c. -6,700), followed by Wholesale, Retail and

¹⁹ [Labour market statistics - gov.scot](#)

Motor repairs (c. -3,800 employees) while there have been notable increases in health and social work (c. +2,700) and finance and insurance (c. +2,000).



There are however signs that the fall in payrolled employees may be stabilising with the number in Scotland increasing by 3,400 through the turn of the year since November.

Recruitment activity

This improvement is also reflected in BICS data which suggests that there has been a recent pick-up in recruitment intentions at the start of the year. Most businesses expect their number of employees to stay the same (60%), however the share expecting an increase rose to 19.8% (up from 16.3% in February) while the share of businesses expecting employee numbers to fall, fell to 9.0% (down from 13.3%).

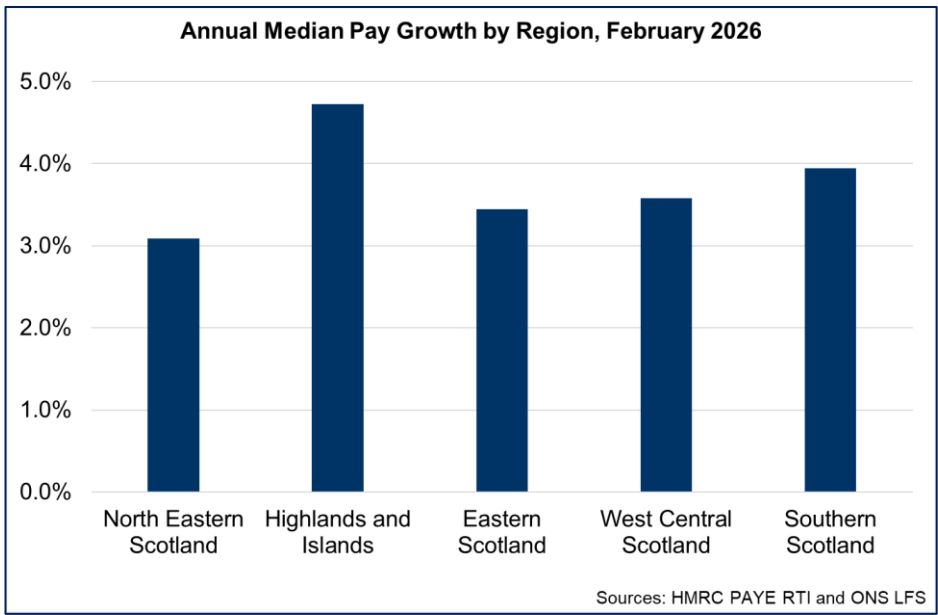


The increase in employment expectations may have a seasonal element to it and the RBS Growth Tracker business survey also indicates a slightly more mixed picture for the start of the year with its

employment index suggesting a moderate fall in staffing levels and at its fastest rate since last August (48.9) (a reading below 50 indicates contracting employment levels). As such, further data in the coming months will provide more insight on whether employment levels have stabilised further.²⁰

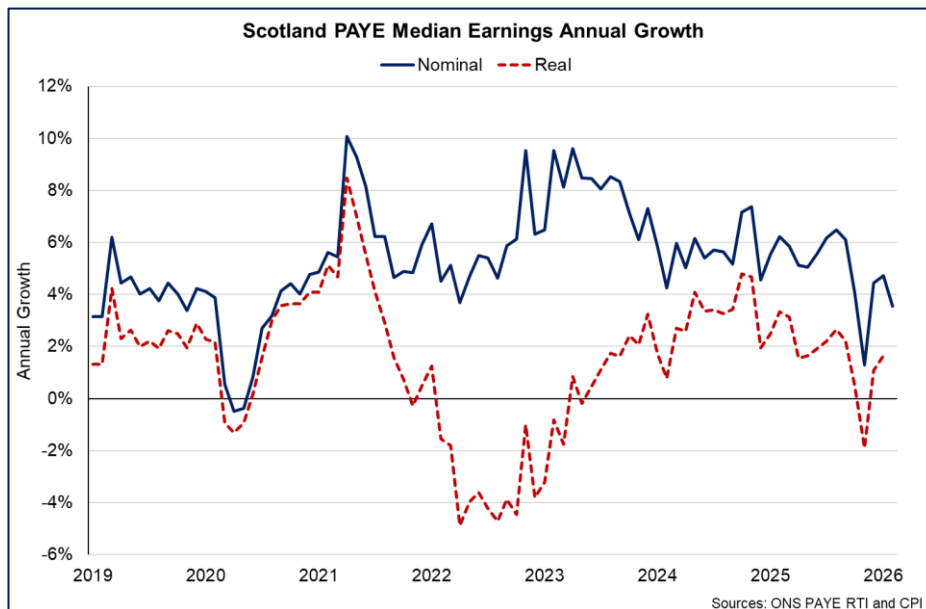
Earnings

Earnings growth remained robust for most of 2025, however latest data indicates that the pace of growth slowed notably in the final quarter of 2025 and into the new year. Nominal median annual earnings growth was 3.6% in February 2026, slower than the average annual growth rate of 5.2% in 2025. Earnings growth was the highest in Highlands and Islands (4.7%), followed by Southern Scotland (3.9%). Earnings growth was the slowest in North Eastern Scotland where annual earnings grew by 3.1%.



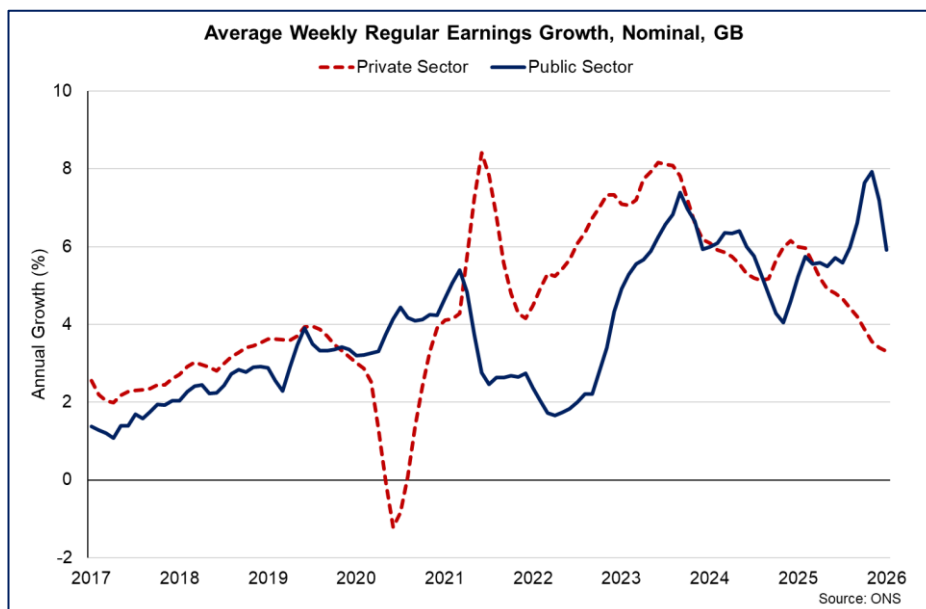
The slower pace of nominal earnings growth in recent months is reflective of the slight loosening in the labour market over the past year and lower inflationary pressures, which have naturally moderated the pace of growth from elevated rates since the end of 2022. Real earnings grew by 1.7% annually in January, once adjusted for inflation, with the annual inflation rate falling to 3%.

²⁰ [Regional Growth Tracker report for January 2026 | Royal Bank of Scotland](#)



At a GB level, nominal earnings growth over the first half of 2025 remained robust in both the public and private sectors. However, in the second half of the year, 3-monthly earnings growth in the public sector sustainably outpaced that in the private sector. In January 2026, the 3-monthly earnings growth in the public sector was 5.9% (down from 7.2% in December) compared with growth in the private sector of 3.3% (down from 3.4% in December).²¹

Pay growth is expected to be slower over this year than in 2025, with latest intel from the Bank of England suggesting that pay settlements for 2026 will average 3.6% compared with 4% in 2025.²²



With labour market statistics experiencing declining response rates, we set out alternative labour market indicators in Box 3, using administrative data.

²¹ [Average weekly earnings in Great Britain - Office for National Statistics](#)

²² [Agent's summary of business conditions - March 2026 | Bank of England](#)

Box 3: Alternative labour market indicators

The Annual Population Survey (APS) and Labour Force Survey (LFS) are key sources for Scottish labour market statistics, covering measures such as employment, unemployment, and economic inactivity. Since the COVID-19 pandemic, the declining response rates for these surveys have led to concerns around the reliability of official estimates of the labour market in Scotland and the UK, and the loss of Accredited Official Statistics status for LFS and APS-based outputs.^{23,24}

Last year, Scottish Government completed Phase One of an assessment for Scotland, exploring the quality of these latest survey estimates and what this means for Scottish labour market statistics.²⁵ The assessment found that Scotland's LFS/APS estimates showed clear signs of increased volatility and uncertainty in the period following the pandemic, reflecting (but not exclusively driven by) COVID-19 impacts and survey changes during this time. The ONS has made progress in mitigating these issues.

Following a decision to end funding for the LFS boost for Scotland from October 2025 due to concerns around achieved sample sizes, the Scottish Government also continues to work closely with the ONS to support the development of the transformed Labour Force Survey, a redesigned, online-first survey expected to launch in late 2026.²⁶

Reflecting ongoing concerns about the reliability of survey-based labour market statistics, the Scottish Fiscal Commission has increasingly drawn on administrative HMRC PAYE Real Time Information (RTI) data on employee and earnings growth to inform their economic and fiscal forecasts.²⁷ Similarly, the Resolution Foundation published analysis in November 2024 outlining an alternative measure of the employment rate in the UK using administrative data sources.²⁸ This suggested that survey-based estimates for those aged 16+ may be understating employment in some periods.

In April 2025, we published a replication of this for Scottish data, finding that the level of employment may have been slightly higher under the new measure, with RTI and LFS-derived 16+ employment rates estimated at 59.8% and 58% respectively in September to November 2024.^{29,30} As shown in the chart below, replicating this approach produces an alternative employment-rate series for those aged 16+ that diverges from the LFS post-pandemic, providing an important supplementary source for interpreting labour market trends, particularly when the

²³ [Request to suspend APS accreditation – Office for Statistics Regulation](#)

²⁴ [Statistics Statement from the Chief Statistician on the Annual Population Survey - Statistics](#)

²⁵ [The Scottish Government's Quality Assessment of the Office for National Statistics Labour Force Survey and Annual Population Survey data for Scotland - gov.scot](#)

²⁶ [Changes to Labour Market Statistics in Scotland: What You Need to Know - gov.scot](#)

²⁷ [Scotland's Economic and Fiscal Forecasts January 2026](#)

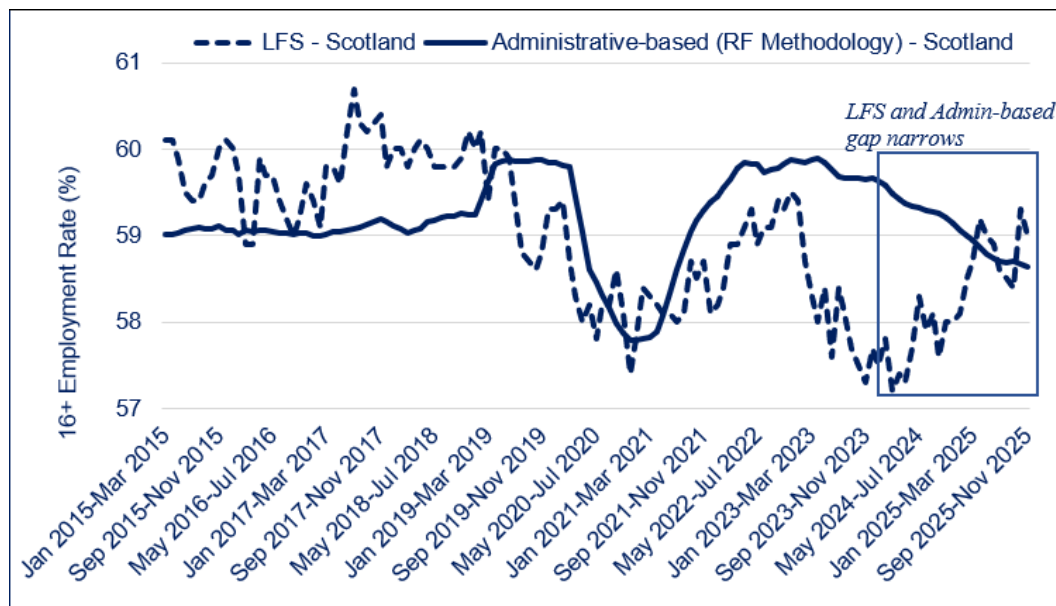
²⁸ [Get Britain's Stats Working • Resolution Foundation](#)

²⁹ [Scottish economic insights: April 2025 - gov.scot](#)

³⁰ The RTI employment rate is now estimated at 59.2% for this period, due to revisions to the RTI backseries.

quality of survey-based statistics is uncertain. Due to RTI data revisions, employment rates reported here may differ from those shown in last year's publication, but the trend remains similar. It shows that – in the latest period September to November 2025 - the rate of employment for those aged 16+ is now closely matched under the new measure (58.6% compared to the LFS-derived measure of 59%).

Chart B3.1: 16+ Employment Rate (%) estimates using Resolution Foundation Methodology vs official LFS estimates



Employment rates for those aged 16+ using both methods are broadly similar prior to the pandemic, though the LFS series is more volatile. Following COVID-19 and a decline in LFS response rates, the series begin to diverge, with the administrative-based series suggesting that the level of employment in Scotland may have been higher than estimated using the LFS. From mid-2024 into 2025 the gap narrows, with convergence largely driven by recovery in the LFS estimate from its low point, alongside gradual easing in the administrative-based series. By the end of the period, the two measures are close. The ONS note that LFS coherence with other labour market sources has improved in 2025, with achieved sample sizes, which had fallen by nearly 40%, back to around 90% of their pre-pandemic levels, although representativeness remains below pre-pandemic levels.³¹ The ONS continue to note that the December 2024 reweighting of the LFS has also improved coherence.³²

Differences between the administrative-based employment measure and the LFS imply that either unemployment, inactivity, or both are potentially lower than the LFS estimates. Given that inactivity is typically larger than unemployment, the Resolution Foundation suggests that, for the

³¹ [Labour Force Survey quality update - Office for National Statistics](#)

³² [Labour market overview, UK - Office for National Statistics](#)

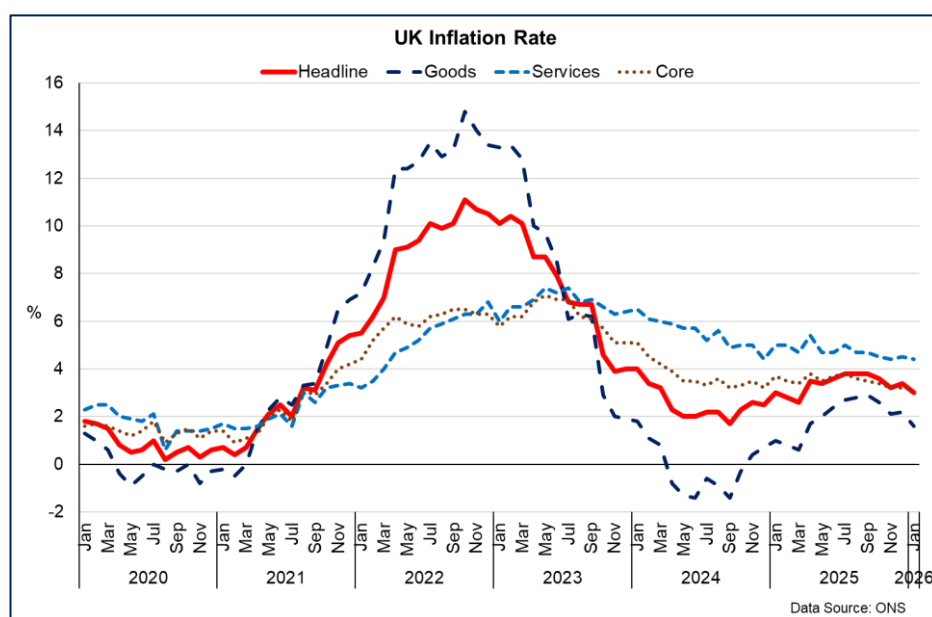
UK, much of the recent difference in its estimates may have been associated with lower inactivity than implied by the LFS.

End of Box 3

Household conditions

Inflation

UK inflation picked up in 2025 from 3% at the start of the year and peaked at 3.8% during the third quarter before slowing to 3.4% in December and 3.0% in January.³³



The easing in headline inflation has been reflected across its main components. Goods price inflation has fallen from 2.9% in September to 1.6% in January while the fall in services price inflation from 4.7% to 4.4% has been more moderate. Core inflation (excluding energy, food, alcohol and tobacco) has maintained its downward trajectory, falling from 3.5% in September to 3.1% in January.

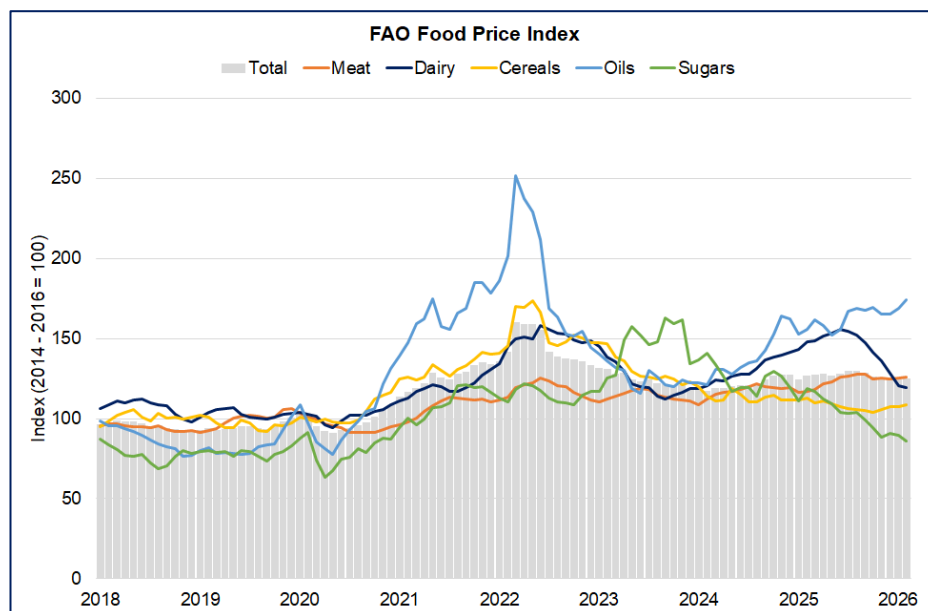
More volatile components of inflation such as energy price inflation and food prices, eased in the second half of 2025 having picked up during the first half of the year. Electricity, gas and other fuels inflation fell from 9.4% in September to 2.1% in January while food and non-alcoholic beverages inflation fell from 5.1% in August to 3.6%. As important aspects of the household budget, the conflict in the Middle East has the potential to impact these aspects of the cost of living, depending on how prolonged the conflict is and the duration of impact on oil and gas prices and wider commodity prices.

³³ [Consumer price inflation, UK - Office for National Statistics](#)

Prior to the conflict in the Middle East, inflation was forecast to fall to around 2% in April, which partly reflects the 7% fall in the Energy Price Cap in that month, which will protect households from any increase in average energy bills until the next price cap at the start of July.³⁴

Reflecting the recent sharp spike in heating oil prices, the UK Government also announced a £53 million support package for heating oil users in rural communities. However, the increase in energy prices has already led to road fuel prices increasing, and inflation is now expected to be higher over the coming months than it otherwise would have been.

The recent easing of food price inflation is also reflected in movements in wholesale prices, with the FAO Food Price Index gradually falling from 128.6 in September to 124.2 in January, albeit it picked up slightly in February to 125.3.³⁵ A prolonged military conflict in the Middle East increases the risk of inflationary pressures in oil and gas spilling over into wider commodities, both directly and indirectly.



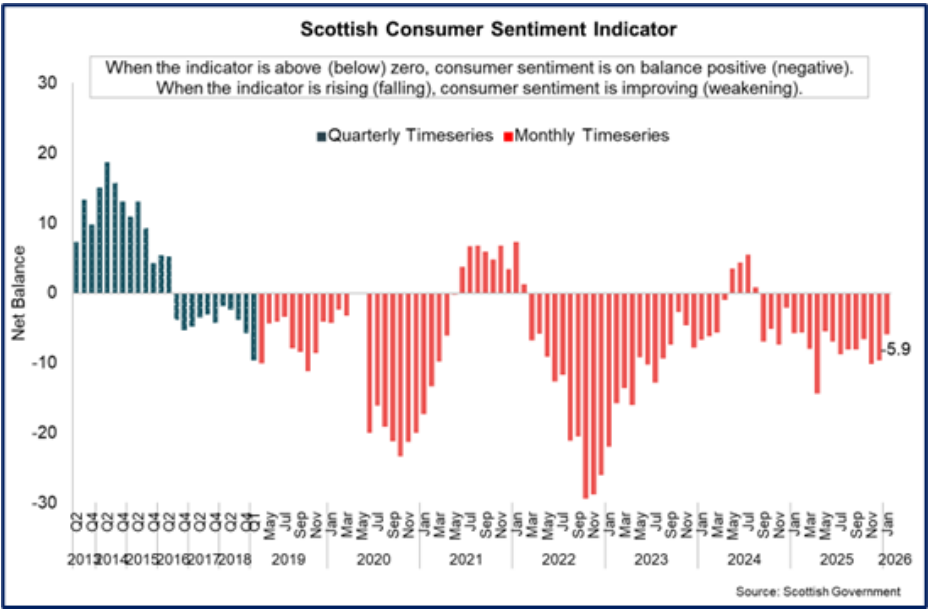
Consumer sentiment

Consumer sentiment in Scotland has remained weak over the past year, likely reflecting ongoing pressures on household budgets and wider economic uncertainty at both a domestic and global level. However, it has been on an upward trend from the second half of 2025, which chimes with some of the improvements in conditions supporting consumers including the falls in inflation and interest rates.

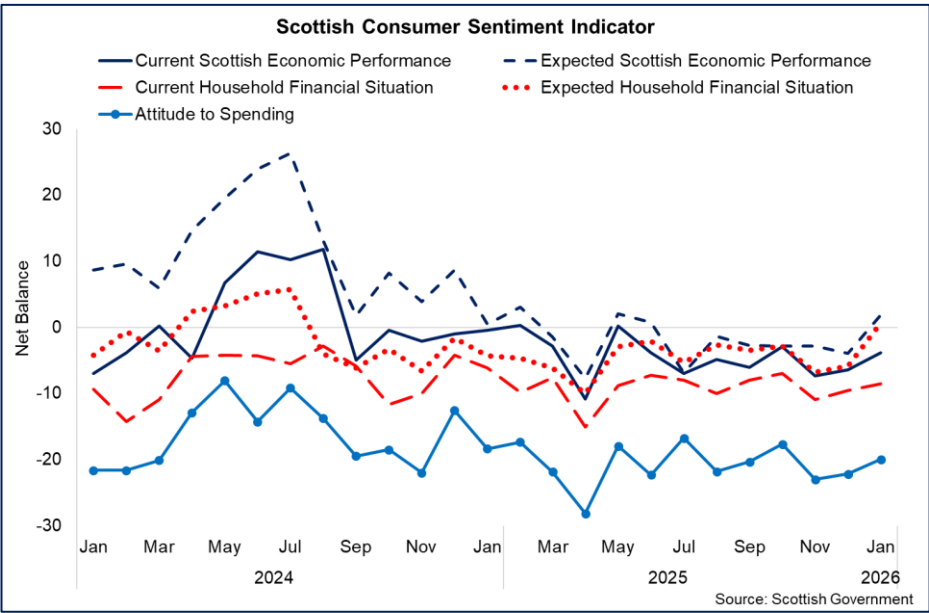
³⁴ [Changes to energy price cap between 1 April and 30 June 2026 | Ofgem](#)

³⁵ [FAO Food Price Index | Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations](#)

The Scottish Consumer Sentiment Indicator stood at -5.9 in January 2026, improving by 3.7 points from -9.6 in December and reaching its highest level since May 2025, indicating a strengthening in consumer confidence at the start of the year.³⁶



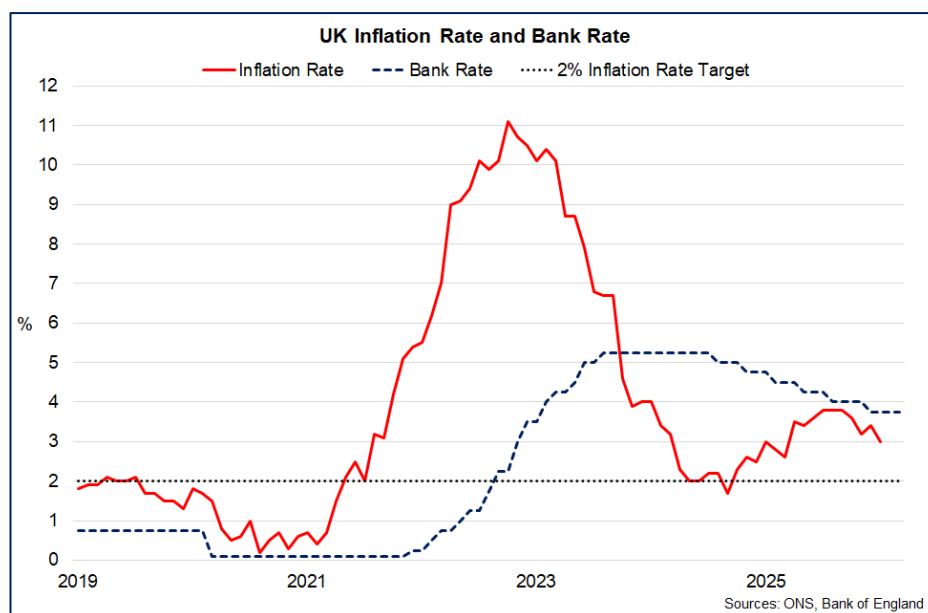
Sentiment across the sub-indicators covering current and expected economic performance, household finances and attitudes to spending remained relatively subdued through 2025. Attitudes to spending continued to be the most negative component, however it and the indicators relating to the Scottish economy and household finances all improved through the turn of the year. Notably, expectations for both the economy and household finances were positive, suggesting improving confidence in the outlook among households.



The moderation in inflationary pressures and reduction in interest rates over the past year have gradually strengthened the economic environment for consumers and households. Interest rates

³⁶ [Scottish Consumer Sentiment Indicator : Monthly Data - gov.scot](https://gov.scot/scottish-consumer-sentiment-indicator-monthly-data)

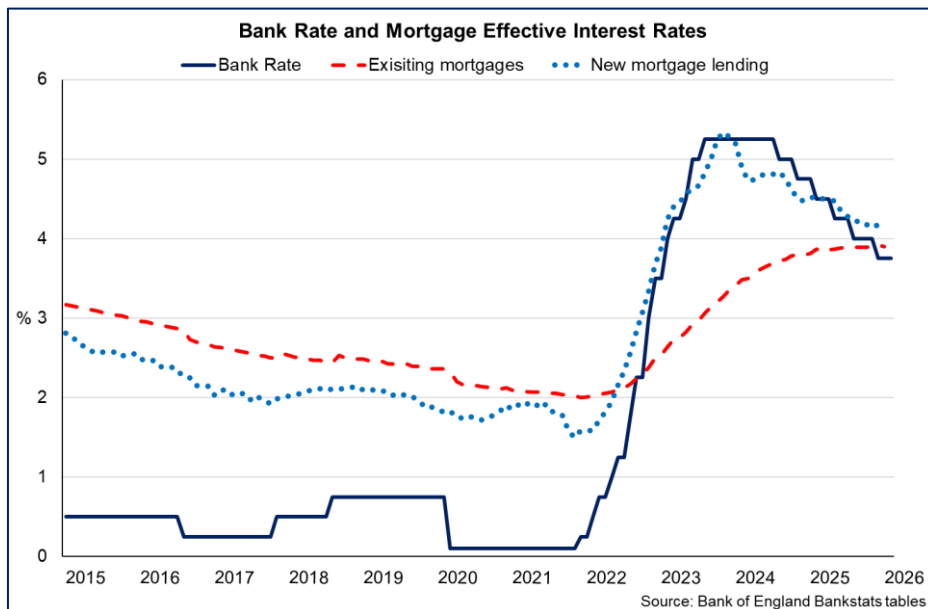
have been lowered four times since the start of 2025 by the Bank of England's Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) from 4.75% to the current rate of 3.75%. However, at their meeting in March, the Bank of England (in line with the ECB and US Federal Reserve) held interest rates unchanged at 3.75% reflecting the recent increase in risks and uncertainty in the inflation outlook due to the conflict in the Middle East. The Bank now expect inflation to remain between 3% and 3.5% over the second and third quarters of this year, higher than their February forecast which projected inflation to settle around 2% over that period.³⁷



The reduction in interest rates over the past year have gradually fed through to the effective interest rates offered on new mortgages and to the effective interest rate on the total stock of mortgages. The effective interest rate on new lending has eased from 4.51% at the start 2025 to 4.1 in January 2026, while the effective interest rate on the total mortgage stock, has further stabilised, rising from 3.8% to 3.9% over the same period.³⁸

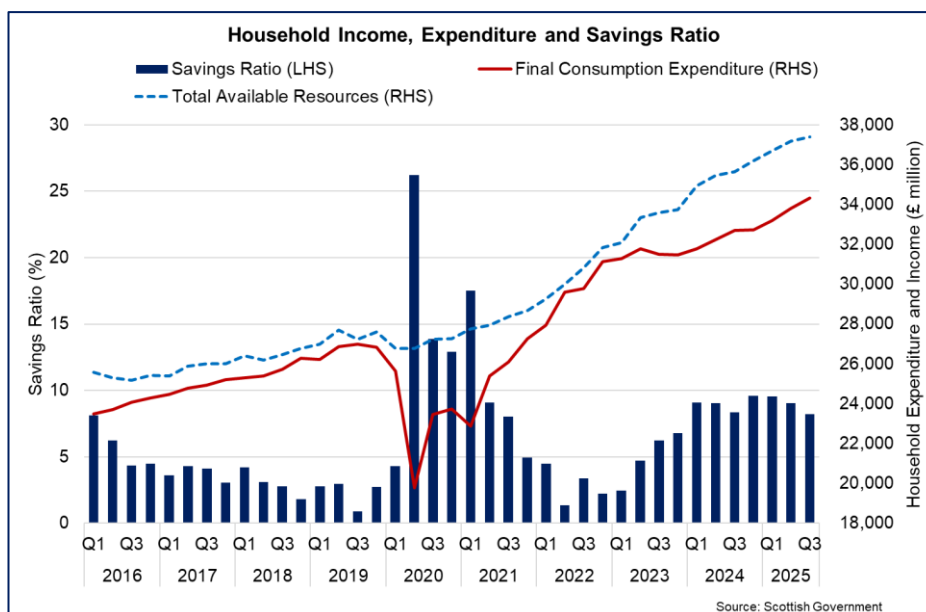
³⁷ [Bank Rate maintained at 3.75% - March 2026 Monetary Policy Summary and Minutes | Bank of England](#)

³⁸ [Effective interest rates - A visual summary of our data | Bank of England](#)



Savings ratio

The savings ratio, a measure of funds available for saving, including pension contributions or debt repayment, stood at 8.2% in Q3 2025, down from 9.1% in the previous quarter and slightly lower than the 8.3% recorded a year earlier.³⁹



Movements in the saving ratio reflect that household spending grew 5% over the past 12-months while disposable income increased by 4.8%.

While expenditure growth has recently outpaced income growth, the saving ratio continues to indicate that households retain some capacity to set aside income, providing an indication of broader trends in household sector finances.

³⁹ [GDP Quarterly National Accounts: 2025 Quarter 3 \(July to September\) - gov.scot](https://gov.scot/gdp-quarterly-national-accounts-2025-quarter-3-july-to-september)

Economic outlook

Latest forecasts

The global economic environment has changed notably since the end of February and the start of the conflict in the Middle East. The disruption to oil and gas supplies from the region, mainly due to the effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz, presents significant risks to the inflation outlook. At this stage, there remains uncertainty over how long the impacts of ongoing military action in the region will last and the likelihood of the global economic impacts spilling over into wider channels with disruption to wider trade flows and supply chains and impacting on business and investment confidence over the year ahead. The impact of artificial intelligence (AI) on the economic outlook is also unclear with both upside and downside risks – Box 4 summarises the latest evidence on the uptake of AI in Scotland.

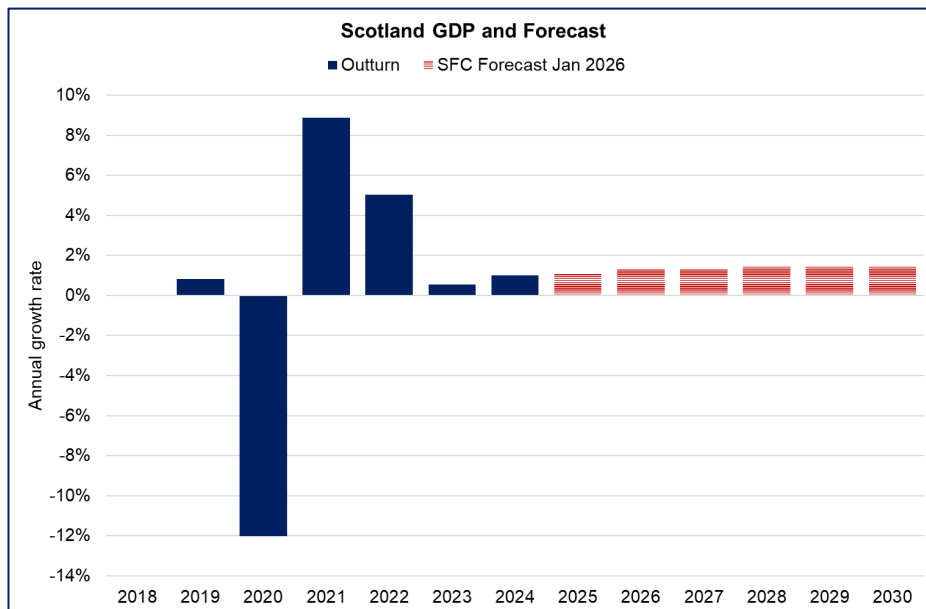
Most key latest forecasts were undertaken before the conflict started and reflected the geopolitical risks and trade policy uncertainty at the time, current weaknesses in demand and loosening labour markets, but an economic outlook of broadly stable inflation and gradually loosening monetary policy.

At a global level, in January, the IMF forecast economic growth to remain steady in 2026 with growth remaining unchanged at 3.3% in 2026 before easing slightly to 3.2% in 2027. At a UK level, at the start March, the OBR forecast UK GDP growth of 1.1% in 2026 and 1.6% growth in 2027 and 2028. The OBR noted that the conflict in Iran, which began after their pre-measure economy forecast was closed on 12 February, could have “very significant” implications for both the global and UK economies, particularly given the associated rise in energy prices. In Scotland, the Scottish Fiscal Commission in January, forecast Scottish growth to remain broadly stable at 1.3% in 2026 and 2027.^{40,41,42}

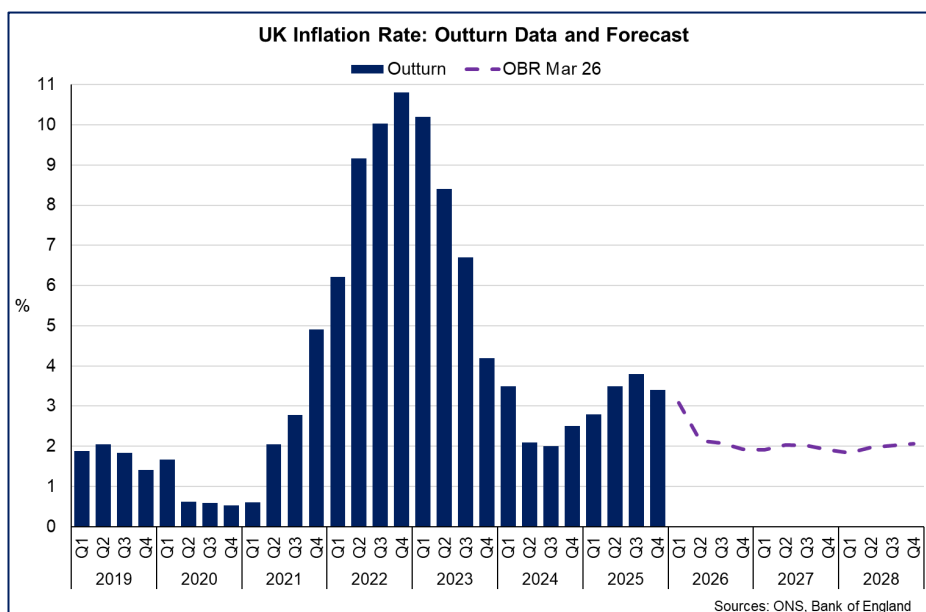
⁴⁰ [World Economic Outlook Update, January 2026: Global Economy: Steady amid Divergent Forces](#)

⁴¹ [Economic and fiscal outlook – March 2026 - Office for Budget Responsibility](#)

⁴² [Scotland's Economic and Fiscal Forecasts – January 2026 | Scottish Fiscal Commission](#)



In March, the OBR forecast UK inflation to fall to around 2% in April this year and remain broadly stable through the forecast period, with markets pricing in one to two further interest rate cuts this year from its current rate of 3.75%. However, the significant increase in oil and gas prices risks inflation remaining higher than forecast and that interest rates will remain higher than they were previously expected at the start of the year. The Bank of England now expect inflation to remain between 3% and 3.5% over the second and third quarters of this year.



There remains significant uncertainty in the outlook for inflation which will depend on how long energy prices remain at elevated levels. In the longer term, under a scenario where there is a sustained oil and logistics supply shock for a year or more and in which there are spillovers from energy into wider commodity markets and continued geo-political tension, we would see greater impacts on economic output channels at a global and domestic level, with potential for a marked slowdown in economic activity.

Box 4: AI technologies: Adoption by Scottish businesses and potential influence on the economic outlook

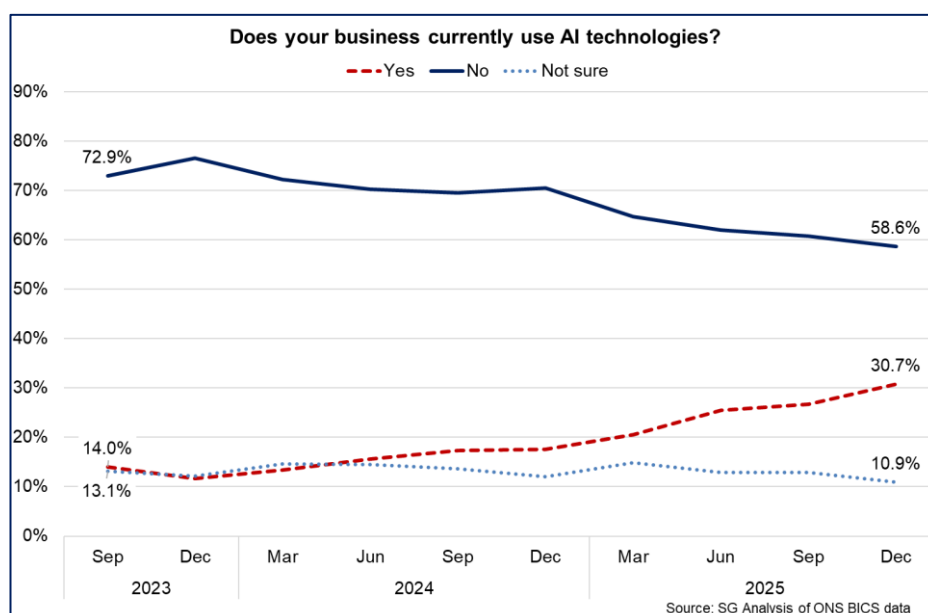
Artificial Intelligence (AI) is increasingly being adopted into operations of Scottish businesses, with recent survey evidence showing increases in adoption across sectors. As AI technologies are being more widely adopted across the economy, anticipation around its potential impacts on productivity and the economic outlook also grows. The path is still highly uncertain but there are some initial projections on its future impact.

This Box provides latest data insights on how Scottish businesses are adopting AI technologies and their expectations on their workforce. This box also sets out some of the assumptions around how AI is influencing the economic outlook.

AI adoption by Scottish businesses

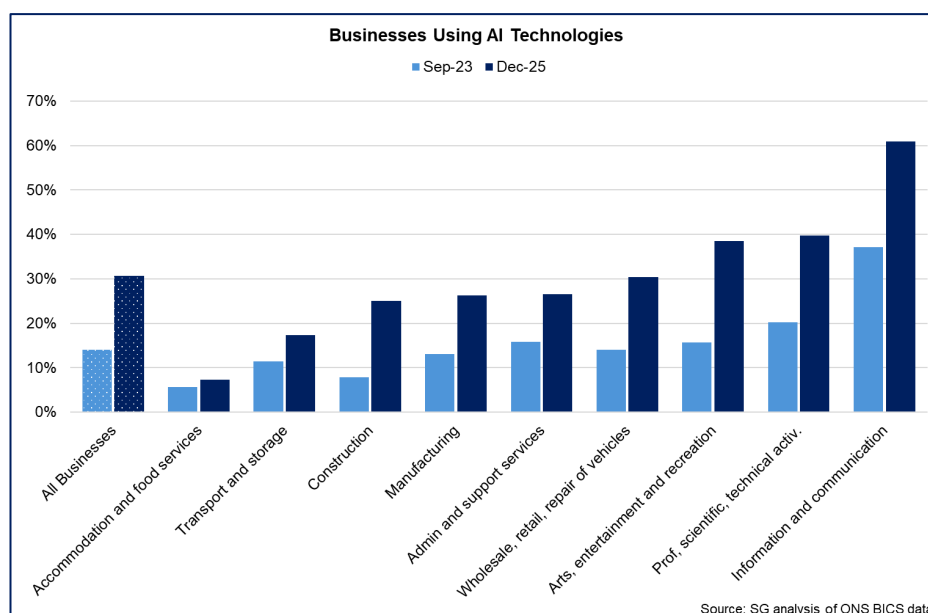
Latest Business Insights and Conditions survey (BICS) data for December 2025 shows that a rising share of Scottish businesses report to be using AI technologies (30.7%, up from 14.0% in September 2023), with larger businesses more likely to report AI usage than smaller businesses (47.0% compared with 28.9%). The Fraser of Allander Institute's (FAI) Scottish Business Monitor for Q4 2025 suggests that the share may be even higher, showing that 50.4% of responding firms report to be using AI technologies to some degree in their operations.

Chart B4.1: Does your business currently use AI technologies?



Expectedly, BICS data shows that the Information and Communication sector continues to report the highest share of businesses using AI (60.9%). Nonetheless, increases in the shares of businesses adopting AI have been observed across all sectors in recent years, reflecting the broad application the technology can have to different business operations.

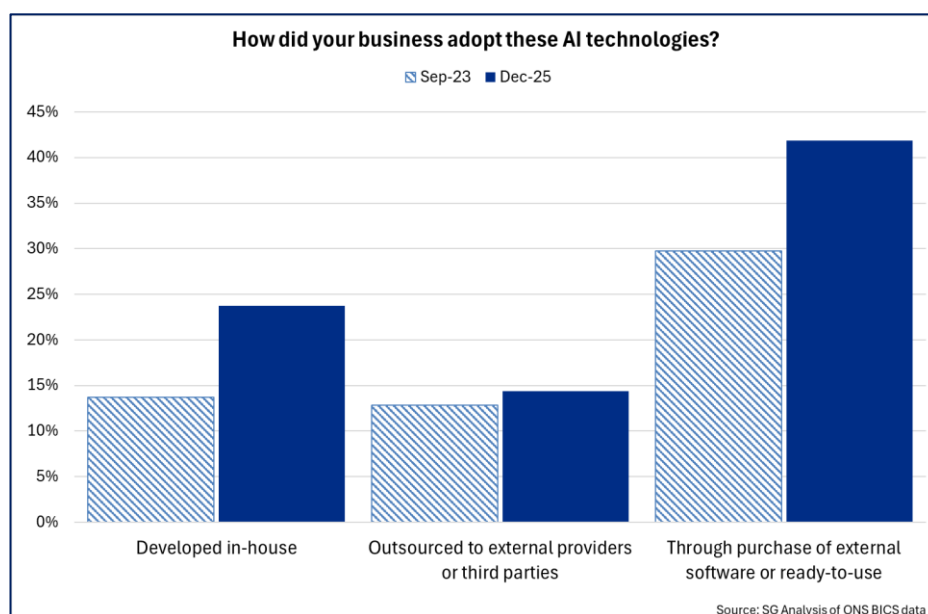
Chart B4.2: Businesses Using AI Technologies



While the types of AI being used by businesses in Scotland vary, the most frequently reported technologies continue to be Large Language Models (LLMs) for text generation (16.8%) and Machine Learning for data processing (12.3%), followed by visual content creation (11.3%).

Most businesses continue to report adopting AI through purchases of external software or ready-to-use AI technologies (41.8%) which highlights the importance of specialised skills and experienced suppliers when it comes to making AI accessible to businesses. Nonetheless, a rising share of businesses report to be developing AI in-house (23.7%, up from 13.7% in September 2023).

Chart B4.3: How did your business adopt these AI technologies?



The most frequently reported reason for Scottish businesses adopting AI continues to be to improve business operations (53.1%) and this is consistent across sectors.

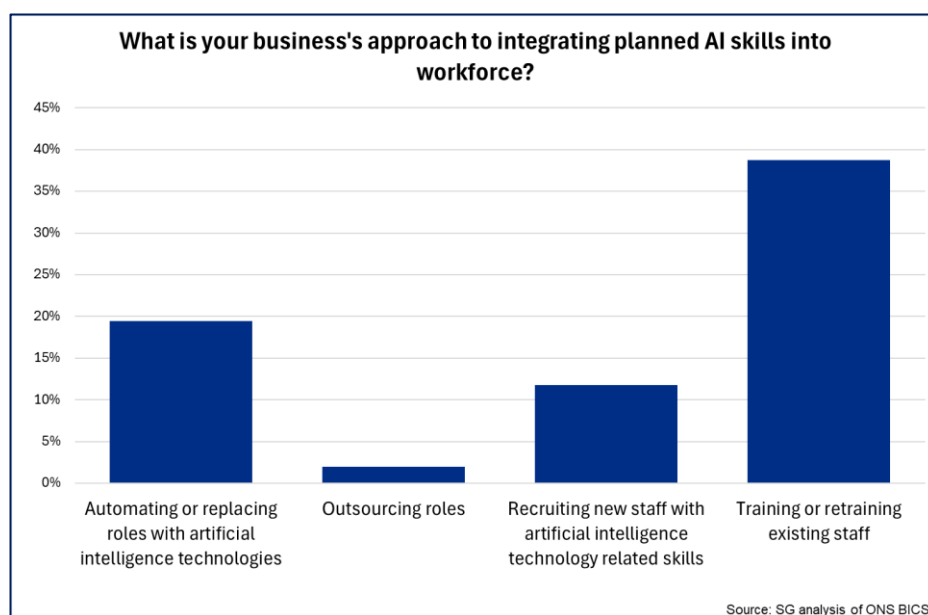
There are some challenges reported by businesses seeking to introduce AI into their business operations. The most frequently reported reason for delays into adopting AI is limited skills, expertise or knowledge of AI (11.0%), followed by no identified use cases (8.5%). However, 43.5% of respondents report to not have been prevented or delayed in adopting AI. 5.4% of businesses report to have been prevented or delayed in AI adoption due to concerns about government regulations or industry standards. The most commonly reported regulatory concern was difficulty of compliance with regulations (89.5%), followed by cost of compliance with regulations (47.6%).

Workforce impacts of AI adoption by Scottish businesses

The majority of Scottish businesses report no change on workforce headcount as a result of adopting AI technologies (51.9%), with only 4.5% of businesses reporting reduced headcount and 1.4% reporting increased headcount. However, in terms of expected impacts, 13.3% report to be expecting a reduction in headcount in the future, with 45.3% expecting no change. A large share of businesses however are still not sure of the future impacts on headcount (40.7%), reflecting the underlying uncertainty around labour market impacts from AI adoption.

Nonetheless, the largest share of businesses report that their aim with integrating planned AI related skills into the workforce is to train or re-train existing staff (38.7%), with a smaller share reporting the aim to be automating or replacing roles (19.4%). A further 11.8% report the aim to be to recruit new staff with AI related skills.

Chart B4.4: What is your business's approach to integrating planned AI skills into workforce?



AI potential influence on economic outlook

The evidence from BICS shows that AI adoption among businesses is steadily growing, consistent with broader global trends in AI-driven capital expenditure, particularly in the US. This, together with the surge in equity investment into the tech and communications sector, highlights the growing importance of AI in the global economy. Expectations of gains from AI adoption and investment are being reflected in the economic outlook, with AI broadly expected to deliver economic growth via productivity gains.

While these gains are yet to be realised in productivity statistics, economy-wide gains are expected to build gradually. The OBR state that while there remains significant uncertainty around both the scale and timing of potential productivity gains from AI, these could materialise following a J-curve pattern over the next decade. In such a scenario, productivity gains would build gradually over time, reaching 0.1 percentage points by year five, before starting to deliver gains exponentially. This would be in line with other general purpose technologies requiring significant investment before delivering gains.

The OBR also model an alternative scenario which is considered less likely but still possible, whereby gains follow an S-curve pattern, occurring more quickly but stabilising over time. Overall the OBR's central estimate is that AI will boost UK productivity growth by around 0.2 percentage points within their forecast horizon.⁴³

The Bank of England similarly project potential productivity growth to pick up over their forecast period but also highlight the risks from AI on their projections. If realised productivity gains are higher than expected, a looser monetary policy stance would be required whereas if the gains are lower, a tighter stance would be required.⁴⁴

There continues to exist great uncertainty around future gains from AI investment and adoption. Downside risks to the economic outlook from AI remain present, with fears that potentially disappointing gains from AI investment could trigger abrupt financial market correction, leading to spillovers throughout the global economy.⁴⁵

End of Box 4

⁴³ [Briefing paper No.9: Forecasting productivity - Office for Budget Responsibility](#)

⁴⁴ [Monetary Policy Report - February 2026 | Bank of England](#)

⁴⁵ [World Economic Outlook Update, January 2026: Global Economy: Steady amid Divergent Forces](#)



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